

CLASSIC CASE
Priya Abraham at an NIV lab in Pune

"Under the microscope, Covid is a pretty looking virus with spikes that stick out like rays of a sun. But it had our warning antenna bobbing..."

PRIYA ABRAHAM
Director, National Institute of Virology

Whereas vaccines made the conventional way using inactivated viruses as BBIL was planning to do required only normal refrigerators for storage and transfer. Bhargava decided it would be best to tie up with BBIL. So, in April 2020, ICMR entered into a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with it to share the intellectual property rights and receive five per cent of the revenue from BBIL's Covid vaccine sales. Covaxin was born.

In his recent book, *Going Viral*, an engrossing chronicle of the development of Covaxin, Bhargava outlines the reason for his decision, saying, "Developing a vaccine for Covid-19 on our own was highly attractive as it would reduce both import costs and dependency on overseas suppliers or governments. While India was known as the pharmacy of the world, it did not have many entirely home-grown products. This was an opportunity to show the world India's ability to come up with cutting-edge products developed with exclusive domestic expertise. We wanted to save lives and do our country proud." In the end, they were able to do both.

Having tied up with ICMR, BBIL began the process of developing the vaccine. With the nation in lockdown, the transfer of a tiny vial containing Covid-19 viruses from NIV's Pune headquarters to Hyderabad 600 kms away proved to be a challenge. The concerned state police forces were requested to permit passage for the consignment. BBIL technicians drove in a car stocked with food as no restaurants were open on the